CAS week reflection

For my CAS week, I participated in the intramural/classical photography CAS week. For our CAS week, we went to Tofino to participate in many place-based activities. On the first day, we were able to go to the Malahat skywalk on the road to Tofino. There, we went on a walk through a scenic view full of tall forests, crystal blue waters and a sunny/clear sky. Going up the skywalk, some of us conquered our fears of heights and walked up a 32-metre spiral staircase to look over the Saanich peninsula and connected mountains. It was definitely a highlight of the trip. From the wind blowing in our faces with the refreshing feeling of the ocean air, it just felt like we were really immersed in the natural surroundings. I could see smiles on everyone's faces not only through my own eyes but also through the pictures we took with our film cameras!

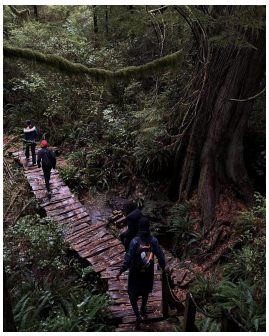
The following day was the main event of our trip, surfing. At first, I was really nervous but also excited. I had surfed once before but never in cold water with wet suits. In addition, the weather was not in our favour so the waves were predicted to be pretty ravenous. However, despite the worries, I decided to focus my thoughts more on the new adventure and bonding experience I'd be having. In the morning, we got our wetsuits on and met up with the Surf sisters (our instructors) and we walked out to the beach with our surfboards. We got a quick lesson on the motions we needed to go through in order to stand on the board and then we got in the water. Thankfully, the wetsuits were very insulating because the water was freezing, plus the rain and wind were pretty extreme. The waves were pretty "gnarly" and rapid so my instructor Alyssa helped me catch my first wave. I set myself up on the board and waited for her cue when I started paddling. (The female representation and leaders also felt very empowering!) When I felt the strong push from the water, I stood up. That one moment made the cold weather worth it. Even though the water and wind were really working against us, being able to stand for a few seconds felt like we were floating on top of the water.

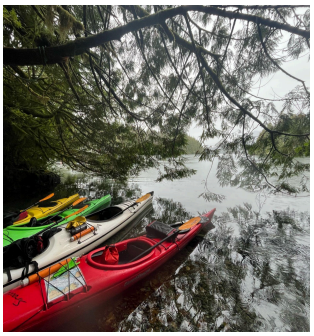
After the first wave, I was on my own. From this, I really learned about determination and patience. Because of the strong, tall and continuous waves, it was really hard to stand up without completely nose-diving into the water. However, in my opinion, the fun part included the many trial and errors of falling off your board, getting up and setting yourself up to do it again. After flopping into the water, rather than frustration I would laugh at myself because I realized that treating myself badly would only make it more difficult and less fun to keep trying. So, instead, I just maintained a determined attitude and focused on the transition from kneeling to standing. After multiple (very funny) failed attempts, I stood up by myself. It made me feel so accomplished because I achieved my goal with my own effort. After that, I was able to stand up four more times. After the lesson, I felt so successful and proud of myself and it was really a great learning experience about gaining new skills through hard work and determination.

The next highlight of the Tofino adventure was the following day when we took a water taxi to Meares island. Meares island is some of the last completely on-logged old-growth forests in the world. Upon arriving on the island, we began walking along a boardwalk tour led by Travis. I learned about old-growth trees, redwood cedar and the importance they have to not only the Indigenous people of the island but also the status of health of the earth in general. Travis told us about how old growth is essential to keeping forests healthy because the monoculture tree farms only result in unnatural side effects such as the increase of forest fires. I also learned about the role of the Tla-o-qui-aht people in saving and preserving Meares island. They were the biggest contributor to the fairy creek protest (a historic and large movement in Canada to protect old-growth forests). If it wasn’t for the work and activism of these individuals, all of the old-growth forests would have been logged because each tree is around 50,000 dollars in producer value. This tour from Travis connected me to nature, and I felt grounded. In his teachings, I learned about Indigenous culture and their connection to the environment and how we can use their ways of life to protect the nature that surrounds us.

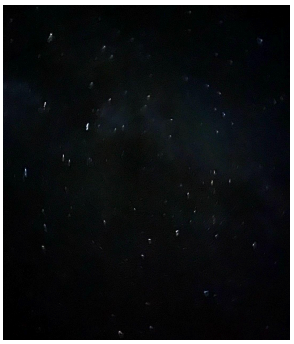
While on the tour, Travis even brought us on a trek off the boardwalk (it was extreme hiking, it felt like wilderness CAS). We really pushed ourselves, physically and mentally. We had to climb through small passageways, jump over fallen trees, climb up steep rock cliffs and slide down muddy grounds. In the end, we were all soaked and covered in mud. Even though it was really difficult, it was so much fun. It was definitely a bonding experience. We persevered through physical obstacles such as climbing up giant rocks and also through problems such as losing half our group. In the end, everyone felt very accomplished (and tired), it was a great immersive experience!

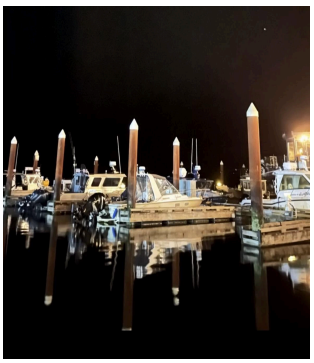
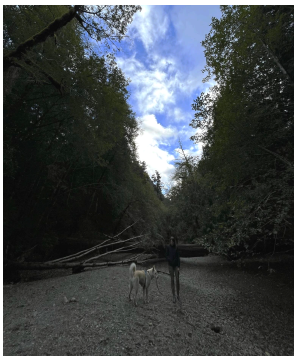
Overall the CAS experience was amazing. It is definitely one of the most memorable and fun moments from Pearson so far. The organized chaos pushed me out of my comfort zone. I learned physical skills such as surfing, hiking, rock climbing and even golfing. I also learned mental skills such as how to stay determined, the importance of courage and perseverance and the value of patience. I was able to bond with my peers and create once-in-a-lifetime memories whilst also recording them through film!












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